SUBROTO MUKERJEE

1911–1960



Taking wing

Subroto Mukerjee was a pioneer in the Indian Air Force and was India’s first Chief of the Air Staff. He was born in Calcutta, into a large and progressive Bengali family. His father was a member of the Indian Civil Service, while his mother was an advocate of social change and a member of the All India Women’s Conference. Educated both in India and in Britain, Mukerjee harboured an ambition to be a pilot and follow in the footsteps of his illustrious uncle, Indra Lal Roy, who had volunteered during World War I. Mukerjee got his chance in 1930, when the Royal Indian Air Force was set up. Mukerjee was one of the six cadets chosen via a competitive exam to be the first Indians to train at the Royal Air Force College Cranwell in England. In 1933, these men made history by becoming the first members of the Indian Air Force.